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Speech 100
September 28, 2021

The Bombing of Hiroshima and Nagasaki

It goes without saying that there were no shortages of atrocities and decisions during World War II whose validity can be called into question. One such decision was the bombing of Hiroshima and Nagasaki by the United States in August of 1945. The atomic bombs detonated over the Japanese cities devastated almost the entirety of the metropolises and killed hundreds of thousands, prompting the unconditional surrender of the Japanese empire. The event has been the source of great debate since, with a plethora of arguments both for and against the bombing. This speech will seek to explain these arguments while remaining impartial, as doing so will provide detailed information on several perspectives to potentially be utilized in future conflicts on miniscule and on grand scales alike.

While there are several arguments in support of the decision to bomb Japan, there are a number that stand out among the rest. The most common argument would have to be that the Japanese empire would not have surrendered if not for the bombings, an argument based on the deeply-laden ideals and values of the Japanese culture. Japan was, and still is to this day, a country that places a great deal of emphasis on the idea that its people must live up to the expectations of society, ahead of their own desires. The term for this value is *honne* and *tatemae*. During wartime, said expectations were to fight valiantly for the country, and even be willing to die for it. There is also the pervasive idea that “the group, and by extension, society, takes precedence over the individual” (A.L. “Honne and Tatemae: human relationships in Japan”). Combining these two things, the belief in Japan during World War II was that surrendering to enemy forces was out of the question, that they would defend their homeland until the bitter end. Historians cite these values as reasons for the bombing of Hiroshima and Nagasaki, since it can be argued therefrom that the decision shortened the war because Japan would not have surrendered otherwise.

This leads directly into the next argument for the use of the atomic bombs against Japan, which is that Operation Downfall, the planned invasion of Imperialist Japan, would have led to significantly more losses on both sides of the conflict. The invasion would have been full-scale in nature, as the United States understood that the Japanese people would not surrender until the very bitter end. It was hypothesized that every individual living in Japan would defend their home to the death, even those living in the countryside. To quote an excerpt from General MacArthur’s reports, “it was presumed that the Japanese would continue the war to the limit of their capabilities, bending every effort to defend the Homeland with their full strength. Such a defense would include not only opposition by their organized military forces but also a fierce and active resistance by the entire population”. (D. MacArthur. “Reports of General MacArthur” p.

401). The report continues to say that victory in Japan would have required the “gearing [of] every aspect of national life to the war effort.” (MacArthur p. 403). Top military commanders had also advised President Truman that the invasion could result in up to one million U.S. casualties. It was through these ideas that the argument to use nuclear warheads against Japan was justified, as not doing so would have led to extremely bloody conflict with heavy losses on both sides, and likely prolonging the war well into 1946 and beyond.

A third reason that has been discussed is that the Manhattan Project exhausted too much money and too many resources for the bombs not to be utilized. The project had begun in 1939 with the intention to develop an atomic bomb before Nazi Germany, and was spurred on by the discovery of nuclear fission by German scientists in 1938. It is estimated that almost \$2 billion were spent on the project, making it the most expensive government project ever at the time. One article argues that “had the United States not used the bombs to end the war, [the] government would have been criticized for spending so much money on a device and then not using it.” (History Crunch. “Reasons in Favor of the Atomic Bombing of Japan”) Said criticism would have been even more intense had the United States carried out Operation Downfall, which would have in turn led to the deaths of many thousands of American soldiers.

As with any decision, there are certainly dissenting opinions regarding the use of atomic weapons to gain victory. It comes as no surprise that the biggest argument against the bombs calls their humaneness into question. Nuclear weapons have often been described as the most terrible weapon known to humanity due to their sheer destructive power. According to a textbook on the history of the United States, the bomb dropped on Hiroshima instantly vaporized “70,000 Japanese citizens” and “In the months and years that followed, an additional 100,000 perished from burns and radiation sickness.” (US History “The Decision to Drop the Bomb”). The mere thought of such a high number of deaths being caused by a single weapon is difficult to comprehend. As such, the event has led to significant trauma among individuals across the planet. This is especially true of Japan, where virtually all of its people have been directly affected psychologically, or physically, or both by the bombing. Even those who survived the blast were subject to radiation sickness, one of the most unthinkably horrible things a person can experience. Further, the magnitude of the weapon certainly struck fear in the hearts of millions of people globally, as they were faced with the sudden realization that their lives could be over in an instant should the decision be made again.

Building upon this idea one can arrive at the next argument, which is that the choice of two major population centers over smaller targets was morally wrong. It has been argued by many historians that the primary goal of the atomic bombs was to “scare the Japanese into unconditional surrender and to impress upon the world the power of the new weapon.” (G. Brumfiel “Why Did the U.S. Choose Hiroshima?”). Thus, a committee decided upon Hiroshima and Nagasaki instead of a smaller target, specifically a military installation in Tokyo Bay, believing such a catastrophic loss of life would be most effective in achieving this goal. Historians have also argued that choosing the smaller target could have been effective as well, since the destructive power of the weapon would still be on full display.

The last of the major arguments against the atomic bomb was that the decision led to an age of nuclear terror in which countries around the world raced to develop more of the weapon. This arms race, though no longer at its height, continues into the present day as several nations, namely the United States, Russia, and North Korea, attempt to acquire or maintain military superiority. It has been argued that the decision to utilize nuclear warheads in World War II largely contributed to and exacerbated the Cold War, in which the United States and Soviet Union produced thousands of bombs. Naturally, a side effect of such an arms race led to a great deal of fear for several decades, a feeling that persists to this day. Had the pure power of the atomic bomb not been displayed against Japan in 1945, the arms race may not have been as fierce, which would have in turn limited the extent of fear in the decades following.

Upon considering all of the arguments in favor and in opposition to the bombing of Hiroshima and Nagasaki, it can be said that the debate regarding the decision will continue for many years. Although the event took place more than seventy-five years ago, the ramifications of the choice have not ceased as it serves as a warning against further use of the weapons in warfare, spawning the idea of mutually assured destruction. While the bombs had a purpose at the time of their use, said purpose has been extrapolated to show that humans have the ability to wipe out the entire planet. This is to say that the world changed on August 6, 1945, where seventy thousand people were killed instantaneously, and an entire city was erased. It is reasonable to hope that the event will continue to serve as an example of great debate and as a lesson in the terrifying capability of the human species.

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